

Women in the Story of Immersive Technology

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ABSTRACT

The contributions of women to the history of computing are under recognized, and computer graphics is no exception. This anniversary of SIGGRAPH is particularly suitable for attending to the role of women in the diverse story of immersive technology. This panel gathers three creative contributors – one from the academy, one from the artworld, and one from industry – to discuss where immersive technology has been and where its headed.

KEYWORDS

History of computing, Women in computing, Virtual reality, Immersive technology

ACM Reference Format:

Rebecca Allen, Elizabeth Baron, Carolina Cruz-Neira, and David C. Brock. 2023. Women in the Story of Immersive Technology. In *Special Interest Group on Computer Graphics and Interactive Techniques Conference Panels (SIGGRAPH '23 Panels)*, August 06–10, 2023, Los Angeles, CA, USA. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 1 page. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3587422.3603105>

1 THE PANEL

The contributions of women to the history of computing are under recognized, and computer graphics is no exception. While much work remains to be done on the contributions of women to computer graphics, the contemporary moment is particularly opportune for attending to the role of women in the diverse story of immersive technology. With momentum building in the commercialization of this technology, both within industry and for consumers, it is an important time to highlight the crucial, yet underappreciated, place of women in the creation and use of immersive technology. This panel takes a step in this direction, gathering three creative contributors to immersive technology: one from the academy, one from the artworld, and one from industry. The panel discussion will treat the contributions and experiences of each panelist – where immersive technology has been – and their thoughts about where the technology is headed today.

2 THE PANELISTS

Rebecca Allen is an accomplished Los Angeles-based artist, who has engaged with computer art and digital technologies since the mid 1970s. While her artwork spans many media and forms, she is known for early and important virtual and augmented reality art installations. Allen's digital and visual work with the group Kraftwerk is well known popularly, with her work exhibited internationally and in the permanent collections of major museums including the Whitney, MoMA, and LACMA. She is also a Research Professor at UCLA with a long history of research in media technology starting at MIT then the Computer Graphics Laboratory/NYIT, and then going on to lead research labs at UCLA, MIT Media Lab Europe, and Nokia.

Elizabeth Baron is currently an enterprise solutions executive at Unity Technologies, producer of a leading platform for interactive, real-time 3D content. She is leader in immersive reality technologies, having worked in visualization, VR, AR, and immersive reality for over three decades at the Ford Motor Company. She holds a degree in CAD programming from Eastern Michigan University.

Professor Carolina Cruz-Neira is a leader in immersive technology research, known for her essential contributions to the CAVE Automatic Virtual Environment as a graduate student at the University of Illinois, Chicago in the early 1990s. A member of the National Academy of Engineering, she enjoyed faculty positions and creating research centers at Iowa State University and the University of Louisiana at Lafayette. She is now at the University of Central Florida, where she is the Agere Chair Professor in the Computer Science Department. Cruz-Neira is an editor and editorial board member for several academic journals.

The moderator for the panel is David C. Brock. He is an historian of technology, the Computer History Museum's Director of Curatorial Affairs, and director of its Software History Center. He focuses on histories of computing and semiconductors as well as on oral history. He is the co-author of *Moore's Law: The Life of Gordon Moore, Silicon Valley's Quiet Revolutionary*.

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SIGGRAPH '23 Panels, August 06–10, 2023, Los Angeles, CA, USA

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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-0144-3/23/08.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3587422.3603105>